

# Rat Detective: Character Recognition and Appeal

## 1. The central recommendation

**Preserve the recognizable core of the existing rat, give him a distinctive way of behaving, and test recognition separately from affection and play preference.** Do not begin with a wholesale redesign, more accessories, or a long biography.

A productive character proposition for this game is: **a dead-serious little detective who refuses to lose his dignity in a ridiculous cheese-ball world.** This is a proposed creative direction, not an established audience finding. It connects the noir costume to the comedy without requiring dialogue, cinematics, or new investigative mechanics.

The desired response—“That’s Rat Detective; I love him; I want to play”—contains several different design problems. Treating them as one “appeal” score can conceal the reason a design fails.

| Goal                   | What success would mean                                                           | What to examine                                                                        |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Recognition            | A child identifies the same character across views, outfits, sizes, and contexts. | Silhouette, feature relationships, color placement, characteristic movement.           |
| Recall and attribution | A child later remembers him and connects him to the name Rat Detective.           | Distinctive cues, consistent name pairing, competing associations, delayed recall.     |
| Affection              | A child understands something endearing or admirable about him.                   | Intent, reactions, humor, vulnerability, repeatable personality.                       |
| Desire to play         | A child wants to inhabit this character, not merely look at him.                  | Responsiveness, competence, expressive actions, personal choice, enjoyable situations. |

This four-part framework is a production and testing recommendation. It is not a validated psychological scale.

Ehrenberg-Bass’s distinctive-assets framework provides a useful narrower distinction: an asset needs both recognition and an association that points to the intended brand rather than competitors. A new character must build those associations; an attractive design does not arrive with them automatically.<sup>1</sup>

**The practical objective is not “as famous as Mario on first exposure.” It is “easier to recognize, remember, understand, and enjoy than the current baseline after comparable exposure.”**

### Scope and confidence

The visual assessment uses the earlier seven-page *Rat-Detective-Visuals.pdf*, especially the character sheet on page 7 and city views on pages 2–3. It does not establish what the current executable, animations, camera, or customization system now contain. No Rat Detective child playtest data were supplied. Recommendations below are therefore candidates to validate, not findings that the present character is failing.<sup>2</sup>

The evidence combines original developer accounts, a published child-avatar study, broader game-motivation research, and explicit design judgments. None of the reviewed sources establishes a universal combination of shapes, colors, or facial proportions that produces a successful children’s franchise.

<sup>1</sup> Ehrenberg-Bass Institute / Romaniuk, “Brands of Distinction”. A branding framework, not a Rat Detective audience experiment.

<sup>2</sup> *Rat-Detective-Visuals.pdf*, seven-page earlier project reference; pp. 2–3 and 7. These are still images, not an inspected current game build.

## 2. What the useful comparisons actually teach

### Mario: visual identity can solve a gameplay problem

Miyamoto's account of Mario's original design ties the cap, moustache, and clothing to severe pixel constraints. Contrasting sleeves and overalls made arm movement easier to distinguish; the face and head treatment reduced difficult details. These are functional design decisions that became identity cues, not evidence that children universally prefer caps or moustaches.<sup>3</sup>

**Application:** judge the rat while running, aiming, turning, and being viewed at actual play size. A beautiful promotional pose cannot establish whether the character works in motion.

### Sonic: the appearance should agree with the temperament

SEGA's official characterization combines speed with independence, impatience, loyalty to promises, and helping others. The useful lesson is coherence: the character's behavior supports the energetic impression of the design.<sup>4</sup>

**Application:** decide what the rat consistently notices and how he responds. "Cool, funny, brave" is not enough to direct animation. "Suspicious glance, decisive action, exaggerated effort to look composed afterward" is actionable.

### Splatoon: start from the activity, not a detachable mascot

Nintendo's developers describe trying different character concepts and arriving at squids because the identity made sense with ink-based actions. The character concept and the game's central material became mutually reinforcing.<sup>5</sup>

**Application:** make the cheese-ball interaction part of the rat's performance and visual vocabulary. A cheese-shaped weapon already does some of that work. His aiming, recoil, reactions, and recovery can do more without adding extra equipment. The right question is what makes *this rat doing this activity* different from an arbitrary cartoon animal holding a gun.

### Kirby: simplicity does not guarantee gameplay clarity

The *Kirby and the Forgotten Land* developers explain that Kirby's rounded form created a particular 3D problem: from behind, it could be difficult to tell which direction he was facing. A famous, simple character still needed gameplay-readability work.<sup>6</sup>

**Application:** the coat's broad shape may identify the rat while failing to show aim direction. Test those separately. Passing a black-silhouette exercise is useful evidence, not a complete character-design certificate.

### Astro Bot: a face and a performance can carry identity without dialogue

Team Asobi describes Astro's shape-changing LED eyes as central to expression and to the visual family shared by other bots. The developer also describes his speech-like sounds as deliberately designed, rather than treating the absence of conventional dialogue as the absence of vocal identity.<sup>7</sup>

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<sup>3</sup> Nintendo, "The Reason Mario Wears Overalls", *Iwata Asks: New Super Mario Bros. Wii* (2009).

<sup>4</sup> SEGA, Sonic Channel character profile (Japanese; undated).

<sup>5</sup> Nintendo, "Got to be Squids", *Iwata Asks: Splatoon* (2015).

<sup>6</sup> Nintendo, *Ask the Developer Vol. 4: Kirby and the Forgotten Land, Part 1* (2022).

<sup>7</sup> PlayStation Blog, "The evolution of Astro Bot's adorable character design" (August 26, 2024).

**Application:** the rat does not need a talking mouth. His eyes, head angle, ears, posture, coat, tail, and optional nonverbal sounds can supply a consistent emotional vocabulary. Any added sound should fit his noir personality rather than defaulting to a babyish squeak.

### Minecraft and Roblox represent a different relationship

Mojang's introduction of additional default skins explicitly expanded the ways players could represent themselves while retaining Steve and Alex. That is not the same design goal as building affection for one tightly authored protagonist.<sup>8</sup>

For Rat Detective, separate "I like that particular hero" from "I like being my own rat in that world." Both are possible. The brand can have one stable representative while playable rats retain controlled variation. A multiplayer avatar system should not accidentally erase the character identity the marketing is trying to build.

## 3. Why Disney characters are more than recognizable outfits

Disney Animation describes visual development as grounded in story, emotion, composition, and the director's vision. Its modeling process also considers characters from different angles and treats clothing and accessories as part of communicating personality and story.<sup>9</sup>

That is the transferable practice: **visual decisions support a recognizable person, not just a category.** A costume can establish "princess," just as a fedora establishes "detective." The character becomes specific through the way that costume, body, behavior, and story work together.

### Ariel as an example

Disney's official Ariel description emphasizes curiosity and independence. In a retrospective interview, co-director John Musker connects her red hair both to differentiation from earlier princesses and to her fiery personality and the underwater color environment.<sup>10</sup>

The important distinction is between *remembering the red hair* and *having reasons to care about the curious, determined character who has it*. A color cue does the former job more directly than the latter. For the rat, a red coat can help recognition; it cannot, by itself, communicate resourcefulness, dignity, or comic persistence.

### What not to infer from famous franchises

Recognizing a famous character is not an experiment that isolates the quality of its design. Prior familiarity, repeated media appearances, and attachment to the experiences featuring that character are mixed together. The existence of successful princesses therefore does not show that a particular face shape would make a new rat equally successful.

This is a methodological caution rather than a claim that design does not matter. Use established characters to study coherent choices. Use controlled tests of Rat Detective to decide whether a proposed change improves *this* character.

### Translate story into a repeatable reaction

A multiplayer character does not need a film-length character arc to have personality. The production challenge can be much smaller: define how he responds to situations that already recur in the game.

For example, a composed detective notices a threat, acts decisively, is briefly disheveled by the result, then corrects his hat as if nothing unusual happened. The repeated contrast is between his serious self-image

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<sup>8</sup> Mojang, "Introducing New Default Minecraft Skins" (2022).

<sup>9</sup> Walt Disney Animation Studios, "Visual Development" and "Modeling" (undated).

<sup>10</sup> Disney, *Ariel*; John Musker, *direct interview in Indie Cinema Magazine* (September 2024).

and the absurdity around him. This is an original performance proposal; it should be compared with the current animation, not assumed to be better because it reads well on paper.

Avoid making him perpetually helpless. The player should feel capable through him. Place the joke in his dignity, reactions, and surroundings—not in compulsory misses, unresponsive controls, or repeated humiliation.

4. Assessment of the existing visual reference



Existing Rat Detective carry and fire poses, cropped from page 7 of the earlier visual reference. No redesign has been applied.

The reference shows a red broad-brimmed hat with a cream band, visible rounded ears, a golden-brown snout, narrowed eyes, a tall red coat and collar, a pink tail, and a yellow cheese-block pistol.<sup>11</sup>

These are observations. The risks and experiments below are design judgments based on the still image, not measured defects in the current game.

| Existing feature                       | What it can contribute                                        | What should be tested                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hat, ears, and band                    | A compact head signature combining detective and animal cues. | Whether the ears remain distinct at small sizes and from the rear; whether the brim hides too much expression.           |
| Narrowed eyes and projecting snout     | Suspicion, attitude, and readable rat anatomy.                | Whether children read “watchful and confident” or “bored, unfriendly, or sleepy”; whether emotional changes are visible. |
| Long coat and raised collar            | A simple main mass and a clear noir costume.                  | Whether turning and aiming remain legible; whether the rear becomes an undifferentiated column.                          |
| Pink tail                              | A strong rat cue and a potential motion signature.            | Whether it survives distance, occlusion, dark surfaces, and animation without visual clutter.                            |
| Cheese-block pistol                    | Immediate absurdity and a connection to the game’s material.  | Whether the cheese reads at play size; whether the character remains identifiable without it.                            |
| Red, cream, gold, and pink arrangement | A candidate color signature already present.                  | Recognition under different lighting and permissible costume variation, without relying on color alone.                  |

<sup>11</sup> *Rat-Detective-Visuals.pdf*, p. 7. The image and listed features are from the earlier reference; risk assessments are this report’s interpretations.

## The distinction problem is specific, not a reason to start over

A red coat and broad-brimmed red hat are not unique to Rat Detective; Carmen Sandiego is a visible example of similar costume codes.<sup>12</sup> This does **not** establish copying, legal infringement, or actual confusion among the intended players.

It does mean that “red detective outfit” is an insufficient distinctiveness claim. The rat anatomy, ear–hat relationship, face, tail, proportions, cheese equipment, and performance should carry the specific identity together. Test plausible near-neighbors rather than assuming the costume alone is ownable.

## Preserve the setting while testing the character

The earlier city reference is intentionally very dark, with sparse illuminated windows and small pools of light. Its local character/background contrast should be examined in moving gameplay rather than “fixed” by replacing the noir palette. A targeted face, hat-band, or silhouette adjustment is a more discriminating first experiment than brightening the entire world.

## 5. A visual system that survives real use

### Choose a small set of primary cues

As a production heuristic, begin with three cue groups: **the hat-and-ear arrangement; the suspicious face emerging above the collar; and the coat-and-tail body shape**. Keep the cheese pistol as a strong supporting cue rather than the only reason the character can be identified.

The number three is not a scientific threshold. It is a constraint against adding detail before deciding what matters. A candidate extra feature earns its place only when it improves a tested problem or supports personality. A scar, badge, monocle, magnifying glass, necklace, and elaborate belt do not become distinctive merely by accumulating.

Document the actual proportions and color values from the approved asset. Do not invent new measurements from a single perspective image. The art team should decide which ratios need to remain stable across future models and promotional illustrations.

### Test more than the front view

For the intended third-person experience, treat the rear and rear-three-quarter views as primary assets. Examine hat tilt, ear visibility, tail arc, torso lean, and the relationship between the firing arm and coat. If the front face is rarely visible during action, give it appropriate visibility in character selection, a lobby, or an end-of-round moment—without interrupting play simply to show it.

Valve’s Team Fortress 2 rendering paper is a useful technical precedent: its characters were designed for rapid identification using proportion and silhouette, with rendering supporting those distinctions. It is a readability reference, not an age-appropriateness or tone reference for this game.<sup>13</sup>

### Use a deliberately demanding review set

Review the approved candidate as a small full-body image, a cropped head, an unarmed pose, a rear view, a flat silhouette, and a grayscale render. Then review it in the actual street and sewer lighting, with effects and other rats present. The stylized coat must remain compatible with collision and aiming expectations; decorative changes should not suggest a radically different vulnerable body.

These checks answer different questions. Grayscale probes dependence on hue. Silhouette probes external form. The head crop probes the promotional icon. Busy gameplay probes recognition under competition for

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<sup>12</sup> *Carmen Sandiego official game site*. Cited only to establish an existing similar costume motif.

<sup>13</sup> Mitchell, Francke, and Eng, *Illustrative Rendering in Team Fortress 2* (2007), section 4.1.

attention. Failure on one test should suggest a targeted change, not automatically reject the whole character.

**Keep brand color separate from match information**

A canonical red promotional rat does not require every player to remain red. Nor should red simultaneously carry the entire burden of mascot identity, team membership, and immediate danger information. Decide how those systems coexist before expanding cosmetics. Preserve redundant non-color cues so a skin, lighting change, or team indicator cannot make the character unrecognizable.

**Make reproduction straightforward**

Try a small sticker, a monochrome emblem, a simple child's description, and a rough drawing from memory. Use these as diagnostic translations, not proof of merchandise demand. The goal is to discover which relationships survive simplification. Do not grade the child's drawing skill; describing or arranging shapes is a valid alternative.

**6. Nonverbal personality and the character people control**

**Proposed personality brief**

**Role fantasy:** an observant, capable rat detective caught in ludicrous combat.

**Internal rule:** maintain professional composure, even when the situation is visibly ridiculous.

**Admired quality:** decisive resourcefulness. **Comic vulnerability:** his dignity is easier to disturb than his determination.

**Behavioral contrast:** restrained suspicion before an event; exaggerated but brief reaction to the result; an economical return to composure.

**Avoid:** sadism, constant panic, empty swagger, compulsory incompetence, or a permanent grin that discards the existing suspicious expression.

This brief is intentionally narrow enough to guide animation and open enough for the implementing artist to discover better performances. It is not a mandate to change the approved animation feel or add a scripted narrative.

**Prototype a small performance vocabulary**

| Existing game situation | Candidate performance                                                   | Essential boundary                                                                        |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Brief inactivity        | Eyes scan; a slight head or ear response suggests investigation.        | Do not sway the aiming view, generate constant noise, or make repeated idles distracting. |
| Preparing to aim        | Head and torso become intent; the silhouette shows purpose.             | Presentation follows input; it must not impose a new aiming delay.                        |
| Firing                  | A crisp response in hand, shoulders, coat, or hat reinforces the shot.  | Never create a misleading second shot, false aim direction, or obscured target.           |
| Moving or turning       | A characteristic lean and controlled tail/coat follow-through.          | Preserve responsive movement, the approved feel, and understandable direction.            |
| Surviving or succeeding | A restrained hat or collar adjustment implies "entirely under control." | Use a safe moment or interruptible additive motion, not an animation lock.                |

| Existing game situation                     | Candidate performance                                        | Essential boundary                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Losing a round or recovering after a mishap | A small dignity-restoring gesture supplies the comic payoff. | Do not extend loss of control, shame the player, or mask the next actionable state. |

Use the current animations as the baseline. Try one or two candidate performances first. If the player cannot reliably read the intended attitude, simplify the acting before adding more poses.

### Intention matters more than animation quantity

A useful micro-sequence is: notice something, commit to an action, respond to its consequence. The viewer should infer what the rat was trying to do. A random assortment of dances and facial movements is not automatically a personality.

Avoid making every action equally exaggerated. If the neutral state is already frantic, an exceptional event has little room to register. For this proposed direction, contrast economical detective behavior with occasional elastic reactions. The exact timing and amplitude belong to animation iteration, not an arbitrary universal rule.

### Sound can reinforce identity without words

Explore a small, consistent set of material sounds: the cheese projectile's character, a subtle cloth response, and perhaps a restrained nonverbal reaction. Test the same clip with and without sound. The performance should remain intelligible when muted, and decorative audio must not conceal combat information.

Do not copy another mascot's vocal cadence, catchphrase, or signature sound. The sound brief should express the same competent-but-comically-dignified character as the animation, not introduce a second personality.

### Never purchase charm with worse controls

Broader game-motivation research links perceived competence and autonomy with enjoyment. It is not a child-specific character-design formula, but it supports keeping the player's ability to act central to the experience.<sup>14</sup>

For this game, a mascot improvement that adds input latency, forces a pose during danger, or makes firing less readable should be rejected even when it looks charming in a standalone clip. Personality should decorate player agency, not compete with it.

## 7. One mascot, many playable rats

### Choose the identity architecture explicitly

A plausible fit for this multiplayer game is **one canonical brand representative plus a family of customizable detective rats**. This is a recommendation, not a claim about the currently implemented roster.

Use the canonical rat consistently in the app icon, key art, major promotional illustrations, and introductory materials. Let the game's rats vary inside a recognizable design family. The same child can then recognize "Rat Detective" and feel "this is my rat." A separate personal name for the mascot is optional; it should solve a real ambiguity, not add an unnecessary second name to learn.

<sup>14</sup> Ryan, Rigby, and Przybylski, *The Motivational Pull of Video Games* (2006). General game-motivation research, not a character-design trial in children.

A CHI 2025 study analyzed interviews and gameplay observations with 48 children aged 8–13. It identified self-representation, alternate identities, social connection, and perceived gameplay advantages among avatar motivations. This is relevant to the audience, but it is qualitative evidence from existing social-game players, not a test of which Rat Detective skin would sell or increase retention.<sup>15</sup>

### Define fixed and variable layers

| Layer                            | Recommended treatment                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Species and body language        | Preserve rat anatomy and the detective family's recognizable attitude.                                   |
| Primary shape relationships      | Preserve agreed hat/ear, face/collar, and coat/tail relationships unless testing justifies an exception. |
| Canonical promotional appearance | Maintain the approved hero's stable color arrangement and recurring portrayal.                           |
| Playable variation               | Explore colorways and restrained costume or expression changes within the family.                        |
| Gameplay information             | Keep identity, team status, aim direction, and collision expectations clear across every option.         |
| Exceptional costumes             | Require deliberate review rather than allowing an accessory to hide all rat and detective cues.          |

Give the default character a complete, appealing identity. Do not deliberately make the unpaid default embarrassing or visually inferior as a lever for children's spending. Personalization can be expressive without being the repair kit for an intentionally unsatisfying base design.

### Build continuity across touchpoints

Keep a short reference sheet connecting the model, icon, promotional pose, expression range, and characteristic gesture. Repeated use should reinforce the same character rather than presenting unrelated interpretations. The logo can accompany the character while name association is being learned; an unfamiliar mascot should not be expected to identify an unfamiliar game unaided.

Do not change the core whenever a new piece of art looks attractive in isolation. Record what changed, why it changed, and whether testing improved. That gives future artists a rationale rather than a brittle list of arbitrary prohibitions.

## 8. The audience hypothesis and the limits of the evidence

"Boys aged 8–12" is a starting hypothesis. The supplied description and comparison franchises do not establish the eventual market. Test it rather than letting it become a permanent design restriction.

For early work, include children in both the 8–10 and 11–12 ranges, with different levels of shooter experience. Include girls and some players outside the assumed core as comparison participants. The purpose is not to prove that everyone likes the game; it is to notice whether the proposed audience was unnecessarily narrow or whether different players interpret the same performance differently.

Avoid treating "for children" as "for preschoolers." Do not assume giant eyes, baby proportions, nonstop smiles, neon color, or gross-out humor are obligatory. Likewise, do not assume all boys want the same aggressive fantasy. The proposed combination of competence, mischief, and recoverable embarrassment needs testing with actual players.

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<sup>15</sup> Fu et al., *Understanding Children's Avatar Making in Social Online Games*, CHI 2025. The authors' observational design does not establish causal effects of customization on this game.

## Evidence that should not be overextended

Research on familiar entertainment and brand characters often uses products rather than games and much younger children. For example, a 2024 experiment involved 66 four- and five-year-olds making object-preference and value judgments. It cannot establish the ideal anatomy or personality for an eight-to-twelve-year-old shooter avatar.<sup>16</sup>

Developer interviews explain design intent and production experience, not controlled causal estimates. A successful developer choosing large eyes does not show that larger eyes improve every character. A study of current avatar users does not show that more cosmetic options will make a new game successful.

For this project, confidence is highest in the need to test actual gameplay readability and keep a coherent character system. Confidence is lower in any specific proposed hat angle, eye shape, gesture, palette variation, or target demographic before testing it with Rat Detective players.

## Parent and child responses are separate inputs

A child may enjoy the character while a parent dislikes the apparent violence or social environment. Test the game's presentation with parents as well as children; do not assume cheese weapons alone settle suitability. This report does not determine an age rating or provide privacy or intellectual-property legal clearance.

For testing, obtain parental permission and the child's assent, make stopping easy, avoid unnecessary identifying recordings, and collect only information needed for the study. Aim for voluntary enjoyment and understandable choices, not anxiety about missing rewards or emotional pressure to keep playing.

## 9. A practical validation plan

The following is a proposed studio protocol. The participant counts, exposure times, and asset sizes are practical starting points, not published universal thresholds.

### Phase A: establish the current baseline

Capture the current model in front, side, rear, and three-quarter views. Record short clips of ordinary movement, aiming, firing, and the existing success and defeat reactions. Use actual gameplay lighting and representative visual clutter, not only studio lighting.

Record the build and asset versions. Write down the intended personality in plain language before testing so the interpretation is not changed afterward to match whatever children say.

Start with approximately 12–18 children for qualitative problem discovery. This is not enough to declare a statistically reliable market winner. Use a separate validation sample and a power-informed design if a later commercial decision requires a quantified comparison.

### Phase B: separate visual comprehension from learned recognition

First, briefly show the character without a label and ask what they see. Questions such as “What kind of character is this?” and “What do you think this character does?” examine rat and detective comprehension. Not knowing the invented name before exposure is not a failure.

Then provide the same limited, clearly named exposure to each candidate. Use the name **Rat Detective** consistently. After an unrelated task, ask for an unaided description and name before showing any answer options. Follow with a recognition lineup containing plausible alternatives: other rats, other detective outfits, and variations of the tested character.

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<sup>16</sup> Williams-Gant, Harden, and Corriveau, *The influence of entertainment and brand characters on children's object preferences and monetary judgments* (2024).

A lineup consisting of one rat, a princess, a car, and a dinosaur mostly tests broad categories. Near-neighbors test whether the specific character was learned. Keep image size, polish, pose, background, and exposure comparable; randomize presentation order.

**Phase C: test personality without prompting the answer**

Show short silent clips. Ask, “What was he trying to do?”, “How did he feel?”, and “What do you think he’ll do next?” Avoid questions such as “Was that funny?” or “Did he look clever?” before hearing the child’s own interpretation.

Compare the existing performance with one revised performance on the same model. Do not simultaneously change the eyes, hat, lighting, music, and gesture, then attribute the result to animation. Test sound as a separate addition when practical.

**Phase D: test embodiment during actual play**

Use a manageable play session, initially around 10–15 minutes. Observe whether the rat’s aiming and movement are understandable, whether personality moments interrupt control, and whether the child voluntarily chooses that character when alternatives are available.

Ask what they would tell a friend about him. Record spontaneous descriptions and meaningful points of confusion. A laugh at one gag, or a stated intention to replay, is promising feedback—not evidence of long-term retention.

**Phase E: test delayed memory and transfer**

At a follow-up roughly 24–72 hours later, ask for the character’s name and description before supplying images. Then test recognition from another angle or an allowed costume variation. A description, sketch, or simple shape arrangement can reveal remembered features without making artistic skill the scoring criterion.

Earlier recognition lineups can teach features. Keep procedures consistent, and use separate groups when a clean delayed-memory estimate matters. Treat each child as a participant; repeated trials from the same child are not independent children.

**Interpret the pattern rather than inventing one appeal score**

| Observed pattern                                   | Best next investigation                                                                |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “A rat detective,” but not this specific character | Strengthen the distinctive feature relationships and consistent name linkage.          |
| Recognized, but described as bored or mean         | Revisit eye behavior, intention, and the difference between suspicious and unfriendly. |
| Liked in a portrait, confusing in action           | Improve camera-facing readability, pose, lighting, or motion before adding detail.     |
| Enjoyed in a clip, not enjoyed as an avatar        | Investigate responsiveness, capability, control interruption, and play fantasy.        |
| Good immediate recognition, weak later recall      | Examine competing associations and whether the same cues and name were reinforced.     |
| Strong baseline, no clear gain from redesign       | Keep the existing design; spend effort on more consequential game work.                |

Predefine the decision that each comparison will inform. Keep interpretation proportional to the sample, look for recurring problems, and resist declaring every positive comment validation of the entire brand strategy.

## 10. Production priorities and handoff

### First: establish what must remain recognizable

Create a compact character sheet with approved front, side, rear, and three-quarter views; actual palette values; critical proportions; the eye-expression range; the unarmed silhouette; and the characteristic hat–ear and coat–tail relationships. Add a brief explanation of why each protected feature matters.

Perform a readability pass in the current game before committing to new anatomy. The first experiment should be the smallest change that could resolve the observed issue: a pose adjustment, a visible patch of face, ear separation, or local value contrast may be enough.

### Second: prototype one signature reaction

Test a single dignity-restoring gesture and a single readable shift from suspicion to intent. Keep them interruptible where appropriate. Compare them against the approved baseline with the same movement and firing behavior. Expand the performance vocabulary only when the first examples communicate the intended character.

### Third: carry the result into brand and avatar rules

Choose the canonical promotional rat, define what playable variants may change, and update the icon and key art from the approved system. Verify the result without the weapon and outside the full-body hero pose. Do not begin with a large skin catalog, elaborate backstory, or voice script.

### Brief for the implementing team

**Objective:** make Rat Detective easier to recognize, remember, and enjoy as a character while preserving the established noir style and approved game feel.

**Proposed creative center:** a serious, observant little detective trying to remain composed in an absurd cheese-ball fight. Favor competence with comic vulnerability over helplessness or cruelty.

**Protected starting material:** the existing rat anatomy, red-hat/coat identity, visible ears, suspicious face, tail, cheese equipment, and the dark city's visual language. These are a baseline to assess, not a ban on evidence-led changes.

**Freedom:** propose alternate visual and performance solutions when they better express the same intent. Do not treat this report's suggested gestures, three cue groups, test timings, or avatar architecture as mandatory implementation details.

**Acceptance evidence:** comparisons at actual play size and camera angles; comprehensible aim and motion; personality understood without dialogue; no added control delay; consistent identity across approved variants; and child feedback that distinguishes recognition from affection and willingness to play.

**Decision boundary:** no wholesale redesign without evidence that smaller changes cannot solve the problem. No expansion of mechanics, lore, or monetization is required by this character brief.

**Bottom line:** children should be able to recognize this rat without his pistol, understand his attitude without dialogue, and enjoy controlling him without his personality getting in the way.

## Sources

The following sources support the factual findings. Project-specific recommendations and test protocols are analytical proposals. Sources were reviewed for this report in September 2026; historical publication dates are retained below.

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